Procedural Representation and Elite Backlash: Experiences of Everyday Discrimination Faced by Scheduled Caste Village Presidents in India

Abstract:

When India's 73rd Constitutional Amendment took effect, Scheduled Castes were elected to village leadership positions in unprecedented numbers. However, procedural representation does not simply translate into substantive empowerment, as SC leaders encounter dynamic resistance aimed to undermine their de facto authority. In this article, I investigate how SC village presidents in Bihar, India experience and perceive backlash while exercising genuine constitutional authority. This study draws on semi-structured, in-depth interviews with three SC mukhiyas who have resisted traditional proxy leadership arrangements. The findings reveal that: (1) formal procedural representation often fails to generate substantive authority, and (2) independent SC leaders who resist proxy status face a multi-dimensional backlash – ranging from systematic bureaucratic obstruction to social microaggressions and the physical destruction of symbolic icons. This research highlights the systematic ways substantive democracy is undermined through everyday exclusion and the necessity of transforming underlying power structures alongside institutional reforms.

Keywords: Political Reservation, Caste, Local Governance, Backlash, India

Introduction

India's 73rd Constitutional Amendment of 1992 fundamentally transformed rural governance by creating approximately 250,000 rural republics through Panchayati Raj Institutions[1], with mandatory political reservations for historically marginalized groups including Scheduled Castes[2], Scheduled Tribes[3], and women (George et al., 2024). This decentralization policy devolved administrative and financial powers to village councils, enabling direct participation of rural citizens in local development decisions. Mahatma Gandhi, long ago, advocated for decentralizing power to villages, empowering common people and creating self-governing communities. On the other side, Dr. B. R. Ambedkar, the architect of Indian Constitution, fundamentally challenged this romanticized vision of village democracy. Ambedkar famously warned, "[…] these village republics have been the ruination of India... What is the village but a sink of localism, a den of

[1] Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) are India's system of local self-government in rural areas, created as a three-tier structure by the 73rd Constitutional Amendment (1992) to promote decentralization, participatory democracy and rural development.

[2] Scheduled Castes (SCs), constitutionally designated communities formerly known as "untouchables" and self-identified as Dalits ("oppressed"), historically subjected to severe social exclusion and occupational segregation under the Hindu caste system. SCs comprise approximately 16-17% of India's population (Census of India, 2011).

[3] Scheduled Tribes (STs) are constitutionally designated indigenous communities, traditional forest-dwelling groups with distinct cultural identities outside the caste system, comprising 8.6% of India's population.

ignorance, narrow-mindedness and communalism" (Ambedkar, 2004: 486). He argued that these institutions are structurally prejudiced to benefit upper-caste interests and intensify caste-based exploitation. The tension between Ambedkar's skepticism and Gandhi's idealization of village self-governance frames contemporary challenge in India's local democratic institutions, particularly the gap between procedural representation and substantive empowerment for marginalized communities.

Comisso (1997) distinguishes procedural democracy, such as formal structures of elections and political quotas, from substantive democracy, which encompasses actual exercise of power, rights and meaningful participation in decision-making. While procedural understandings of democracy focus on methods of decision-making, such as voting, representation, and accountability, substantive democracy concerns itself with the actual outcomes and protections delivered to citizens, including economic and social rights (Spicker, 2008). The 73rd Amendment successfully created procedural mechanisms through devolution of power and mandatory reservations to oppressed groups, yet elected representatives face persistent challenges translating de jure authority into de facto power (Behera, 2011).

This study draws on Mansbridge and Shames' (2008) theory of backlash as "dynamic resistance," the use of coercive power by dominant individual or groups to regain lost capacity to enact their preferences and interests when challenged by marginalized individual or groups. When Dalit mukhiyas exercise genuine political power in India's Panchayat Raj Institutions through political reservations, they threaten the naturalized privileges of dominant castes, who may react with backlash manifesting as microaggressions, violence, and exclusionary practices to reassert the lost power as capacity. I also draw from Sue et. al.'s (2007) framework of racial microaggressions – microassault, microinsult and microinvalidation – to understand subtle forms of discrimination.

The existing scholarship extensively documents elite capture in Panchayati Raj, wherein traditional power holders maintain de facto control by installing compliant proxy candidates from reserved groups (Waheduzzaman et al., 2018; Rajasekhar et al., 2018; Teltumbde, 2011). These proxies, typically wives, daughters-in-law, or bonded labourers of the existing dominant caste mukhiyas[4], hold office nominally while actual authority remains with upper-caste men. If Scheduled Caste elected representatives refuse proxy status and assert genuine political agency, they face severe backlash including casteist slurs, humiliation, harassment, and sometimes direct violence (Rao, 2017; Rao, 2018b; Nagaraj, 2021).

The literature on gender empowerment reveals a parallel dynamic of male backlash on women empowerment, where women's entry into male-dominated spaces often triggers patriarchal

[4] Mukhiya is a Hindi term for the elected head of a village council (gram panchayat). I use words 'village president' and 'mukhiya' interchangeably.

backlash – a renewed determination by men (a dominant group) to reassert hierarchical control through violence, intimidation, and controlling behaviour. Cullen et al. (2024) find experimental evidence from India showing that men punish empowered women at double the rate of control group women, with backlash driven by men holding conservative gender attitudes. Erten and Keskin (2018) demonstrate that education-induced improvements in Turkish women's labor market outcomes led to increased psychological violence and financial control behavior by male partners. Similarly, Berry et al. (2020) document that Kenya's gender quota implementation triggered patriarchal backlash including physical attacks on female candidates, public stripping of women politicians and supporters, verbal abuse labeling politically active women as "prostitutes," and institutional resistance from male-dominated parliaments refusing to fully implement constitutional gender requirements.

These patterns suggest a broader phenomenon: when policies are enacted to empower historically marginalized groups without transforming underlying power structures, entrenched elites often respond with intensified oppression to maintain substantive control. However, scholarship on backlash against caste-based empowerment remains underdeveloped. This study addresses this gap by examining backlash against *Dalit*[5] panchayat leaders in India who exercise genuine political authority rather than serving as proxies for dominant castes. This study therefore asks: how do independently acting *Dalit* panchayat leaders experience and perceive backlash in their everyday political and social interactions while holding office? This question addresses a critical empirical gap by focusing on *Dalit* leaders who occupy the contested middle ground between elite capture and direct physical violence.

Data and Methods

In January 2026, I conducted semi-structured in-depth interviews of three *Dalit* mukhiyas in Bihar to investigate lived experiences of *Dalit* mukhiyas navigating everyday discrimination while holding office. This purposive sampling (Patton, 2002) was essential because *Dalits* constitute the most historically discriminated group in India's caste hierarchy, providing critical insights into how entrenched inequities persist despite empowerment measures. I restricted the sample to only male participants because as a male researcher, I recognized that women mukhiyas might be reluctant to discuss sensitive experiences such as sexual harassment, potentially constraining data collection depth (Berry et al., 2020). This limitation restricts access to important dimensions of discrimination intersecting caste and gender. Interviewees were approached because they were: (a) scheduled

[5] Dalits, formerly known as "untouchables" and part of India's lowest social stratum, represent a marginalized group often considered outside the traditional Hindu caste hierarchy (outcastes). Dalits are legally coded as Scheduled Castes in the Indian Constitution. I will use “Dalits” and “Scheduled Castes” interchangeably.

caste men, (b) elected head of the village council, (c) exercising genuine authority rather than serving as proxy candidates. I contacted the participants through a local organization working in Bihar. Each interview was conducted in Hindi via WhatsApp calls; audio recorded with informed consent and lasted approximately 40-60 minutes. I transcribed recordings and translated transcripts using Claude for Education, a licensed arrangements with LSE ensuring data privacy compliance. The transcriptions were then coded for patterns and common themes manually (Braun and Clarke, 2006). While I use Sue et al.'s (2007) microaggressions taxonomy as sensitizing framework, I employed inductive, data-driven coding rather than deductively applying predefined categories.

Ethics and Reflexivity

I obtained verbal consent from all participants before beginning interviews by audio recording their agreement after clearly explaining the research objectives, their right to withdraw at any time, and how their data would be used. I ensured transparency by avoiding any deception about the study's purpose and guaranteed confidentiality using pseudonyms, with no identifying information appearing in publication of results. Beyond formal procedures, I provided a comfortable and confidential space for participants to discuss sensitive topics including caste-based discrimination and violence, without fear of about information reaching local power holders who might retaliate.

The interviews contained references to violence, including one participant's father being murdered during leftist movements and another recounting a fourteen-year-old Dalit girl's death in caste-based violence. While such accounts are deeply troubling, violence and premature death remain sadly commonplace experiences within Dalit communities in rural Bihar, forming part of the collective social reality that shapes political consciousness. Throughout interviews, I remained observant of participants' emotional state, monitoring for signs of distress when they recalled difficult lived experiences or mentioned incidents of violence. I was prepared to immediately pause or stop interviews if participants showed discomfort.

As a researcher from non-SC background affiliated with an elite international institute conducting research on *Dalit* communities, I recognize the inherent power asymmetries and ethical responsibilities this positionality entails. I do not share the lived experiences of caste-based oppression. I approach this research with awareness that my understanding of caste discrimination remains partial and mediated through intellectual engagement rather than embodied knowledge. Participants may have moderated accounts of particularly humiliating experiences, uncertain whether I would fully comprehend the depth of indignity involved. I acknowledge the limitations of my outsider perspective and remain deeply conscious about being positioned as an extractive researcher who benefits professionally from documenting others' suffering. My ideological commitment to anti-caste politics and decentralized self-governance motivated this research. I

recognize that this normative position may predispose me to sympathize with *Dalit* presidents, potentially influencing how I interpret observational data. Throughout analysis, I remained reflexive about this tendency, grounding interpretations firmly in participants' own voice.

Findings

The thematic analysis revealed systematic ways through which *Dalit* mukhiyas experienced subtle resistance and exclusion while exercising their constitutional authority. Despite holding elected office, participants faced persistent efforts to delegitimize their leadership and prevent substantive democratic participation.

Bureaucratic Roadblocks and Institutional Gatekeeping

Participants consistently described encounters with block officials characterized by deliberate obstruction, disrespect, and differential treatment compared to upper-caste mukhiyas. A participant reported:

"*If there's an upper caste mukhiya, whether it's the Block Development Officer or CEO, they sit and converse well with them.*"

In India, last names are often used to decipher one's caste identity. Local officers react with immediate hostility upon identifying participants' caste through surnames on official documents. One participant recounted visiting the Sub-Divisional Officer:

"*When we gave the application to them, as soon as they saw our caste from our surname, they became furious and came outside to fight with us.*"

Local officials systematically refused to meet with *Dalit* mukhiyas, creating deliberate barriers to access. Officials even declined invitations to constitutionally mandated *Gram Sabha* meetings, demonstrating systematic avoidance of *Dalit* leadership. One participant described repeated attempts to discuss the beneficiary list of housing scheme:
"*Even two days ago, we went to meet the Block Development Officer. He refused to meet us. On the phone he asks, 'What is your issue?' We went to meet him one day, but he made excuses and avoided meeting us. The second day we went again, but he refused to meet.*"

Information withholding emerged as a particularly insidious form of bureaucratic microaggression. Participants were deliberately kept uninformed about scheme beneficiary lists, preventing them from fulfilling their responsibilities to their constituents. This deliberate opacity undermined the mukhiya's authority in the eyes of villagers. One mukhiya described the consequences:

"*I am telling you we haven't been provided with that list yet. But public comes and asks me, 'Mukhiya ji, is my name on the list or not?' I don't have the list. I am being kept in the dark based on my caste… If I were upper caste, I would have gotten that list."*

File processing revealed a systematic pattern of obstructing SC mukhiya's work, with approvals and NOCs delayed indefinitely for *Dalit* mukhiyas while upper-caste counterparts received prompt service. This procedural undermining made governance perpetually stalled. One participant explained:

"*Our Circle Officer, I'm telling you that for many years… he hasn't done any work of ours until today. Especially when he hears our name, whichever file of ours goes, he'll keep it pending. The matter is definitely based on caste.*"

Social Microaggressions and Symbolic Delegitimization

Community members employed various tactics to undermine the dignity and authority of Scheduled Caste mukhiyas through social exclusion, derogatory language, and questioning their legitimacy. Despite holding elected office, participants continued to be addressed with caste-based slurs. One participant recalled attending a death ceremony where he was initially welcomed:
"[...] *But other people from Yadav community came down from the roof and were abusing the host very much. They clearly said, 'When you had to feed Chamars, you shouldn't have invited us.'*"
Another participant described overhearing whispered comments:
"Some don't talk upfront but behind your back. This is how people would say, 'isn't he a Chamar?'"

Despite legally abolishing untouchability, food-related purity-based discrimination still persists in various parts of India. At a social function, objections arose when a Scheduled Caste mukhiya handled food service. Even when hosts defended mukhiya's role, guests pressured them to remove him from handling food. The participant recalled the incident of managing food distribution at a crowded event:
"*I was handling food distribution on the request of the host, as they were busy. I was feeding everybody. But some guests, I suppose… they felt that this bloody Chamar is handling our food. So, then they went to the host and asked to make me stop distributing food.*"

Newly elected Scheduled Caste mukhiyas faced initial social boycotts, with community members deliberately avoiding official interactions. This refusal to engage functionally paralyzed governance in the initial period following election. One participant explained:
"*They wouldn't come to me for any work initially*."

Economic status became weaponized to question capability to running for office. During electoral campaigns, a few upper-caste people emphasized lack of financial resources to delegitimize candidacy:

"*People would tell me that suppose tomorrow someone from our village, met with an accident and admitted to hospital, needs ₹10,000, how will you give them the money? When a person becomes mukhiya, you are supposed to stand up in such situations and help people.*"

False accusations and character assassination emerged as systematic strategies to delegitimize *Dalit* mukhiyas. One participant described multiple complaints filed against them by their own ward members:
"*People from Yadav community accused that mukhiya is acting arbitrarily, according to his own will, withdrawing money as he pleases, he doesn't listen to us… So, two-three times these people filed complaints to the district officer. After that, investigation happened, and nothing came out."*

Elite Strategies to Maintain Control

When facing a *Dalit* candidate who cannot be controlled, village elites resorted to electoral violence. Electoral violence includes barging into polling stations, seizure of voting instruments and fabricating votes, or intimidating voters to coerce electoral choices for or against particular candidates. Booth capturing, voter intimidation and intoxication represent direct assaults on democratic processes when elite preferences diverged from electoral outcomes. One participant described efforts to defeat him in the election:
"[…] *some people from Yadav community tried their best to loot booths this time to defeat me. They thought I won't lose by fair voting, so get the public drunk and loot the booths.*"

After mukhiya post comes under reservation, upper-caste elites commonly expect that the elected *Dalit* mukhiya should function as their puppet. Elite capture in Panchayati Raj Institutions has been extensively documented from both caste perspectives and gender perspectives. One participant articulated this starkly: "*They want a person who will sign where they ask him to, he will do what they say; they want such a mukhiya who walks around carrying a pot on his head… They want that whatever the puppet they make out of them…*"

Another participant estimated that among reserved mukhiyas:
"*If there are one hundred reserved mukhiyas, only five will be those who make independent decisions. The rest say or announce whatever decisions their master make.*"

This reveals how widespread proxy arrangements reduced political reservations largely symbolic rather than substantive in their empowerment effects.

Resistance to Ambedkar's Symbols and Rights Assertion

Dr. Ambedkar is revered as the foremost leader of anti-caste movement who championed *Dalit* rights and social equality. Opposition to public commemoration of Dr. Ambedkar emerged as a particularly revealing dimension of upper-caste resistance. One participant protested that before

him taking office, Ambedkar's presence was entirely erased from panchayat office. When asked if Ambedkar's photograph was in the office before 2016, he stated simply: "*No, there was no trace of it.*"

After damaging Ambedkar's statue in a community building twice, some people have threatened to destroy village gate, if it's named after Ambedkar. A participant states that these are not merely acts of opposition to Ambedkar's symbols, but resistance to genuine empowerment of *Dalits* and their rights assertion.

Discussion

This study reveals systematic mechanisms through which substantive democracy is undermined for Scheduled Caste mukhiyas in rural Bihar despite constitutional guarantees of formal authority. Political quotas successfully create procedural representation but encounter persistent resistance from upper-caste elites through discrimination, exclusion and intimidation. These findings contribute to thick description of how independent *Dalit* leaders continuously negotiate authority against entrenched caste hierarchies.

The bureaucratic microaggressions and exclusion extend Comisso's (1997) distinction between procedural and substantive democracy by revealing specific mechanisms that make formal authority ineffective. Local official's refusals to meet *Dalit* village presidents, deliberate information withholding, and indefinite work approval delays demonstrate how bureaucratic gatekeeping prevents translation of constitutional authority into actual governance capacity. This challenges assumptions that procedural reforms automatically produce substantive empowerment (Waheduzzaman et al., 2018; Rajasekhar et al., 2018; Teltumbde, 2011). Former upper-caste mukhiyas and local bureaucrats often maintain close ties and informal networks built over years of shared governance. When *Dalit* mukhiyas come to power, administrative apparatus actively resists power redistribution. Participants' explicit acknowledgment that upper-caste mukhiyas receive prompt meetings, information access, and swift work approvals highlights how caste identity determines bureaucratic treatment rather than official position. This aligns with Behera's (2011) argument that prevailing socioeconomic systems make it exceptionally challenging for *Dalit* representatives to function effectively.

The social microaggressions demonstrate Sue et al.'s (2007) microaggression framework applicable on caste-based discrimination. Caste slurs persisting three years into tenure and food-related discrimination based on untouchability practices (*microassault)*, and capability questioning based on economic status (*microinsults)* collectively function to demoralize and delegitimize Scheduled Caste leadership without direct violence. Initial reluctance by upper-caste villagers to

approach *Dalit* mukhiyas illuminate how communities enact informal sanctions based on person's identity (*microinvalidation*). Scheduled Caste mukhiyas must prove legitimacy through prolonged competence demonstration while upper-caste counterparts enjoy presumed authority or merit. False accusations and character assassination reveal how traditional hierarchy coordinate discrediting efforts against assertive *Dalit* leaders, aligning with Cullen et al.'s (2024) findings on backlash mechanisms. Cases of obstructing development work in *Dalit* settlements and violence against assertive women *Dalit* mukhiyas (Rao, 2017; Rao, 2018b; Behera, 2011) are common. This demonstrates how resistance intensifies when marginalized leaders materially benefit their communities, threatening resource monopolies sustaining elite dominance.

Fierce resistance to Ambedkar symbols and rights awareness provides empirical support for Teltumbde's (2011) theoretical argument about why dominant castes resist genuine empowerment of marginalized community. Complete erasure of Ambedkar's presence from panchayat office, subsequent statue destruction, and threatening to destroy the structure reveal that anti-caste symbols, such as Ambedkar, itself threatens traditional hierarchies. When one participant explained: "[…] *They don't want that rights should be clearly told to everyone in Gram Sabha on a mic*." This underscores how dissemination of public knowledge on constitutional rights through official platforms directly threatens information monopolies enabling exploitation of oppressed caste groups. This suggests that Scheduled Caste leaders combining Ambedkarite symbolism with rights awareness efforts face particularly intense resistance.

Elite strategies documented in this study demonstrate the sophisticated adaptations traditional power holders employ to preserve dominance despite institutional reforms, extending Heinze's (2025) findings on elite tactical flexibility. The strategic identification and placement of compliant proxy candidates reveal how formal reservation compliance coexists with continued elite control over actual decision-making (Waheduzzaman et al., 2018; Rajasekhar et al., 2018). Electoral fraud and violence when facing autonomous SC candidates demonstrate how democratic processes themselves become contested terrain, with elites employing direct coercion when proxy arrangements fail to materialize (Teltumbde, 2011). However, while extreme cases of physical violence against assertive *Dalit* leaders like Krishnaveni (Rao, 2017) garner attention and documentation, the everyday mechanisms of elite backlash – microaggressions, bureaucratic obstruction, social exclusion, and psychological intimidation – remain largely unquantified and understudied. Further systematic research is needed to document the prevalence and severity of these subtle yet pervasive forms of resistance that operate continuously to undermine *Dalit* mukhiyas' substantive authority, moving beyond anecdotal evidence to establish the scope and patterns of caste-based backlash in local governance across different contexts.

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Appendices

APPENDIX 1: INTERVIEW TOPIC GUIDE

- I will introduce myself
- Thank them for agreeing to talk
- Explain the purpose of the study, how data will used, confidentiality, and consent
- Permission to record and consent for the interview

1. Before the Election: Political Entry and Motivations

- Tell me about your motivation to participate in electoral politics and how this journey started.
  - Probe: Did you decide to fight the election on your own will or did somebody motivate you?
    - If yes, who motivated you? What do you think was their reason for motivating you?
- What were the challenges and concerns you faced while taking this decision?
  - Probe: From family and friends – what were their concerns?
  - Probe: From outsiders – what were their concerns?
- Coming from a Scheduled Caste background, how were your relations with village elites before contesting – upper caste families, traditional powerful people, local bureaucrats?
  - Probe: How did these people treat you before you became mukhiya?

2. During the Election: Challenges and Pressures

- What were the major challenges you faced while fighting the election?
- What pressures or temptations did you go through during the election?
  - Probe: Were you forced to take back your nomination? Can you tell me more about this? (Don't take just yes/no answer, explore more)
  - Probe: Were you bribed or asked to act as a proxy president? Can you tell me more? (Don't take just yes/no answer, explore more)

3. After the Election: Experiences While in Office

- How do people and villagers treat you as a Dalit president?
  - Probe: Are they welcoming or hostile towards you? If hostile, can you explain with examples? (Don't take just yes/no answer, explore more)
- How did influential or upper caste people from your village react to your win as Panchayat President?
  - Probe: Have you experienced or sensed any displeasure from them? Can you describe how and why?

    - Probe: Why do you think they don't like you being elected as the village president? (Ask for specific examples or incidents)
- What are the challenges you face on a day-to-day basis for being a Dalit mukhiya? Or how do they try to create problems or sabotage your work or decisions as the president?

4. Response and Agency

- How do you usually respond to these incidents, behaviors, or attitudes?
- Does exercising your agency trigger more reactions from them? Can you give some examples?
- Is there anything related to this topic that you think we haven't discussed yet that you would like to share?

5. Closing and Demographic Information

Thank the participant for their time and valuable insights. Collect demographic information:

- Panchayat name, block, and district
- Participant's name (for record only, will be pseudonymized)
- Reservation category (SC/ST/Women)
- Approximate age
- Number of terms served as mukhiya
- Previous political experience (family members as mukhiya/ward members)
- Main source of family income
- Approximate panchayat population and Scheduled Caste population percentage
- Dominant caste groups in the panchayat

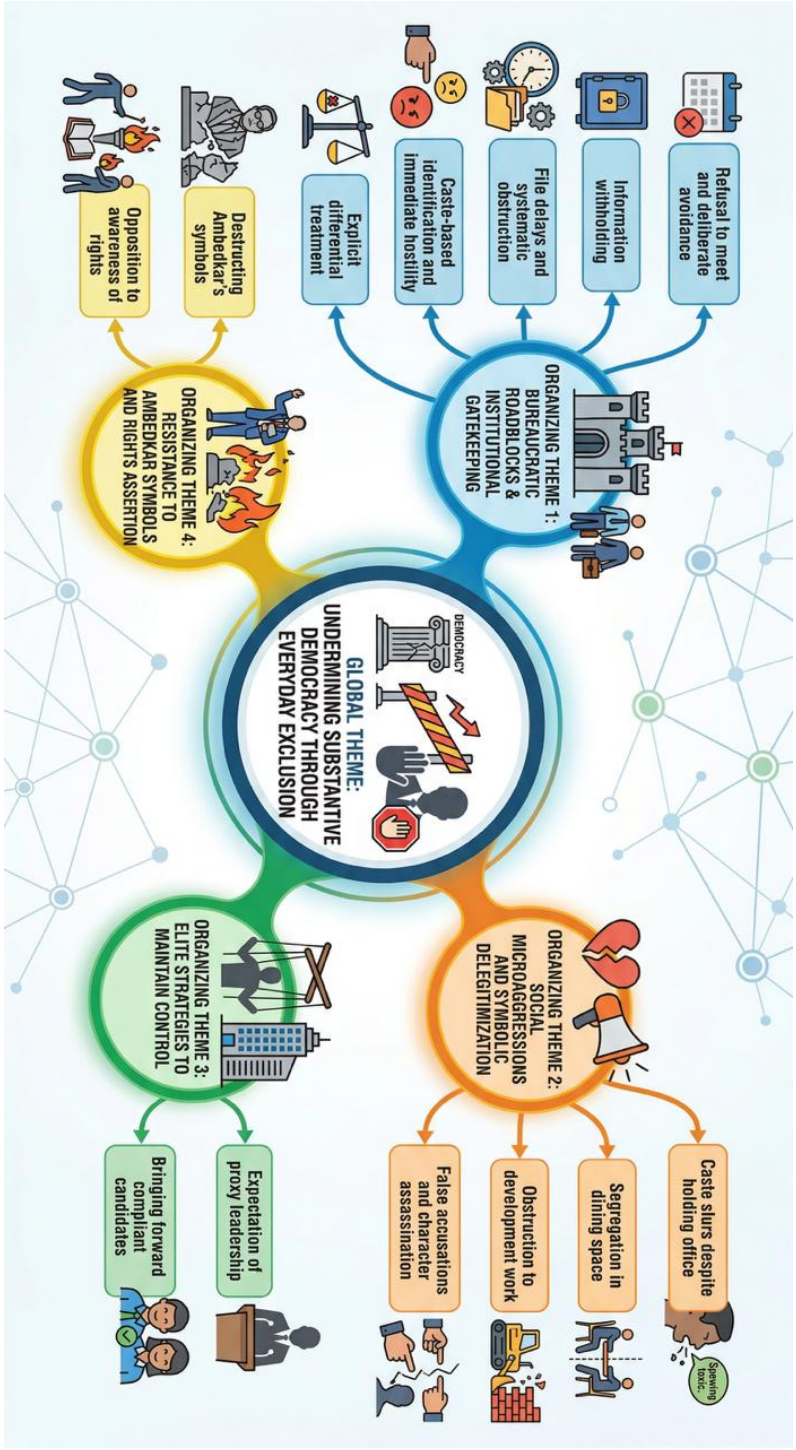
Remind participant of confidentiality and thank them for their participation.

APPENDIX 2: CODEBOOK

RESEARCH QUESTION: How do independently acting *Dalit* village heads experience and perceive backlash in everyday political and social interactions while holding office?			
GLOBAL THEME: Undermining Substantive Democracy Through Everyday Exclusion			
ORGANIZING THEME	CODE	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE QUOTES
Bureaucratic roadblocks and institutional gatekeeping	Refusal to meet and deliberate avoidance	Block Development Officers and other officials systematically refuse appointments, avoid meetings, or create barriers to access specifically for SC mukhiyas	"We went to meet the Block Development Officer. He refused to meet us... We went one day, then he made excuses. The second day we went again but he refused to meet. If we were upper caste, the Block Development Officer wouldn't have had the audacity to not meet the village president."
	Information withholding	Deliberately denying access to official lists, schemes information, and documents that mukhiyas are constitutionally entitled to receive	"The public comes and asks me, 'Mukhiya ji, is my name in the list or not?' I don't have the list, I'm being kept in the dark based on caste. If I were upper caste here, we would have gotten that list. The checking in the panchayat is happening without my knowledge."
	File delays and systematic obstruction	Deliberate delays in processing files, NOCs, and approvals specifically targeting SC mukhiyas while processing similar requests from upper-caste mukhiyas quickly	"Our Circle Officer...for many years he's been in Punpun, but he hasn't done even one of our works till today. Especially when he hears our name, whichever file of ours goes, he'll keep it pending. Everyone gets NOC but we don't get NOC. The matter is definitely based on caste."
	Caste-based identification and immediate hostility	Officials reacting with anger or aggression upon identifying the mukhiya's caste identity through surnames on official documents	"We have a Sub-Divisional Officer here. We had a small problem with the Public Distribution System. When we gave the form to them, as soon as they saw our caste from our title, they became furious and came outside to fight with us."
	Explicit differential treatment	Observable differences in how officials treat SC mukhiyas versus upper-caste	"If there's an upper caste mukhiya, whether it's the Block Development

		mukhiyas in similar situations	Officer or CEO, they sit and converse well with them." "Even today, evaluation is done based on caste, this is clear." "If he were Dalit, we would have had a conversation."
Social microaggressions and symbolic delegitimization	Caste slurs despite holding office	Use of caste-based slurs and derogatory references even when person holds elected position	"Other people from Yadav community came down from the roof and were abusing the host very much. They clearly said 'When you had to feed Chamars, you shouldn't have invited us.' This was about 3 years ago when I became mukhiya for the second time."
	Segregation in dining space	Objections to SC mukhiyas handling food or eating with upper castes at social functions	"There are two wards in our panchayat where even today Dalits are not given food. At weddings or death feasts, they are not fed. People would say we'll feed you but after everyone else eats. And you'll have to take your own plate and go soak it in the river."
	Obstruction to development work	Physical obstruction and harassment when building infrastructure for Dalit communities	"We were building a road for a Dalit settlement, Ravidas community. People were obstructing it, stopping it, saying it won't be built. We had to call the police. When police came, they said if it's being built, what harm is it to you? So, people ran away. Tell me, we had to call police to do our work."
	False accusations and character assassination	Filing false legal cases, making unfounded accusations, or spreading rumors to delegitimize SC mukhiya's moral authority	"People from Yadav class accused us that mukhiya is acting arbitrarily, according to his own will, withdrawing money as he pleases. So, two-three times these people went and gave complaints to the district officer. After that investigation happened, nothing came out."
Elite strategies to maintain control	Expectation of proxy leadership	Elite expectation that SC mukhiyas should function as puppets, signing papers without independent decision-making	"They want a person who will sign after we give him bribe. They want such a mukhiya who walks around carrying a pot on his head. They want that whatever puppet we make, we tie a rope

			around his neck and tie him to a peg, like a domesticated animal."
	Bringing forward compliant candidates	Elite strategy of identifying and supporting SC candidates willing to function as proxies rather than independent leaders	"Upper caste people want that these people shouldn't be able to come here. They make full efforts in this way. But the exploiters don't come forward properly. They bring our people. They know very well how to use our people."
Resistance to Ambedkar symbols and rights assertion	Destructing Ambedkar's symbols	Physical destruction of statues, threats against gates or buildings honoring Ambedkar	"Babasaheb's statue there was broken twice. Because people's pain was this that I also tell people about their rights." "We're making an entrance gate. On that, we've written Ambedkar Dwar on stone. People are saying that the day it's put up, they won't let it be put up."
	Opposition to awareness of rights	Resistance to SC mukhiyas educating community members about constitutional rights in public forums	"They don't want that rights should be clearly told to everyone in Gram Sabha on mic. They want people to remain in darkness, and I want to bring this to light. We talk about equality. Will they want equality?"

APPENDIX 3: THEMATIC ANALYSIS MAP

This thematic map visualizes the relationships between the codes, sub-themes, and the central theme, emerged from the data. The map is generated by Google Gemini (Model: Nano Banana Pro).